

ENLIGHTEMENT The Kashi Vishwanath temple at night



"UNPLANNED DEVELOPMENT HAS DESTROYED THE RELIGIOUS AND SPIRITUAL IDENTITY OF KASHI AND ESTABLISHED IT AS A TOURIST TOWN. TAMPERING WITH THE CULTURE OF KASHI IS A SERIOUS ISSUE"

–VISHWAMBHAR NATH MISHRA
Professor, IIT BHU, and mahant of Sankat Mochan Temple

Ganges was the only famous hotel in Varanasi. Now, we have a dozen new hotels in this category. Right now, there are more than 2,500 big and small hotels in Varanasi." Even so, there is a scramble for hotel rooms "even in the off-season" (April-September). The Babatpur airport now gets some 60 flights daily. Says Sharma, "The Babatpur airport is being expanded at a cost of Rs 1,000 crore. The air strip will be made longer and wider, so that even wide-bodied aircraft like the Airbus A380 can land here."

Not everyone is happy with this mad rush of tourists, though. Siyaram Yadav, owner of the famous Yadav Hotel in Dhausabad area who had a moment in the spotlight with his 'Modi roti' in 2014, says, "The tourist influx has led to heavy traffic on the roads leading to the Kashi Vishwanath Dham. Varanasi's narrow roads have added to the mess, and there are traffic jams on these routes all the time now. The businesses in these areas have slowed down."

To deal with the traffic jam and the safety of tourists, a police commissionerate has been set up in Varanasi. Sharma says, "Road-widening work is going on in the city on a large scale. A total of five roads, including the roads coming from Mughalsarai, Ghazipur and Azamgarh towards Varanasi, are being converted into six-laned ones. New parking areas have been created at four places in the city. All the traffic now coming from south of Varanasi will be able to go towards Babatpur airport without entering the city." Being Modi's parliamentary constituency also means there is a constant stream of ministers and officers from the Centre and state government descending on the city, which, critics say, has added to the vehicular chaos.

The prime minister's visit this time around could see schemes worth another Rs 2,000 crore being inaugurated. Government sources say this is just the prelude, the frequency of the PM's visits to the holy city are only likely to increase as the 2024 general election approaches. ■